A Conversation with Srinivasa Ramanujan

Interviewer: Mr. Ramanujan, your formulas seemed to flow from an entirely different well of understanding. How did they come to you?

Ramanujan: An equation for me has no meaning, unless it expresses a thought of God. The goddess Namagiri would write the formulas on my tongue or in my dreams. I would simply wake up and record them.

Interviewer: G.H. Hardy, your collaborator at Cambridge, was famous for his strict rigor. How did the two of you work together, given such different approaches?

Ramanujan: Hardy was the scaffolding, and I was the architecture. I saw the patterns, the infinite series, the way numbers danced together in the void. Hardy demanded proof, the rigorous stepping stones. He often said I was a man of intuition, while he was a man of logic.

Interviewer: Did you find his insistence on proof frustrating?

Ramanujan: Sometimes. When you can see the destination so clearly from the mountaintop, it is tedious to carve a path through the dense forest below. But I understood its necessity for the Western mathematical world.

Interviewer: Your work on partition functions and mock theta functions is now being used to understand black holes, a concept barely known in your time.

Ramanujan: Truth is eternal. The forms mathematical truths take are merely the garments we dress them in. If they describe the cosmos, it is because mathematics is the language the cosmos itself speaks.